

THE CAPACITY TO SUSTAIN THE WORLD'S POPULATION

SUSTAINABLE BIOSPHERE INITIATIVE

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

William J. Sutherland (1956–)

BEFORE

1388 England's Parliament makes it illegal to throw waste into public watercourses such as ditches and rivers.

1970s British scientist James Lovelock and American microbiologist Lynn Margulis develop the Gaia hypothesis.

AFTER

1992 Canadian ecologist William Rees introduces the concept of the "ecological footprint" to describe human impact on the environment.

2000 Dutch Nobel laureate Paul Crutzen claims we are in a new geological epoch, the Anthropocene ("Age of Humans"), due to the severe ecological impacts humans make on the planet. The date on which the Anthropocene started is still being debated.

The Sustainable Biosphere Initiative (SBI) emerged in 1988 due to the efforts of the Ecological Society of America (ESA) to establish what scientific research should be prioritized given the limited funding available. At this time, the field of ecology was undergoing a transition towards